

has signed an MoU with the UAE. Plus, we also have our own business development department, which is constantly looking for opportunities. For us, in every geography that we enter, we must be sensitive to cultural differences, regulatory frameworks, and their style of working.

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Have you identified the target global markets?

We are focussing on developing countries where there is an appetite due to high cash usage and low digital adoption. Regarding interoperability, especially cross-border remittances (P2P) and merchant payments, our focus is on regions where Indians live and travel, like Southeast Asia, Europe, North America, the Gulf, and Australia. We have gone live with merchant payments in the UAE, Singapore, Nepal and Bhutan. In addition, the India-Singapore corridor is live for cross-border remittances (P2P). Bhutan is the first country to issue the RuPay card.

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Could the Singapore model serve as a blueprint for future partnerships?

Indians can now seamlessly receive remittances from Singapore directly into their bank accounts in real time. The tie-up for P2P took about a year. It takes time. There are currently half a dozen Indian banks which are live. It was an RBI-approved pilot, which is successful. We are designing for the entire ecosystem. There is currently a \$1,000 limit for transfers. We are working on [improving] it. The Singapore model is like a template for future partnerships. The vision and the mandate is to make India self-sufficient in cross-border transactions with select countries.

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How does NPCI or India gain from expanding UPI globally?

UPI has been a huge success in India. If Indians are showing so much confidence in a payment product that is efficient and far superior to traditional options, why not make it global and provide others with the same level of experience? It's an organic evolution of thought for us as well. We won't be dependent on others to empower our citizens to carry out transactions internationally. For a country like India, we are ambitious. We are looking to enable countries to achieve sovereignty by establishing their own payment systems. We want to empower them so that they can be independent. Our focus is on developing platforms that will endure for decades, if not centu-

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ries. We aspire to play a bigger and better role globally.

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NPCI has a tie-up with global payments service facilitators like Worldline and PayXpert in the UK. Tell us about these partnerships.

There is no NPCI-like player in the European market. These tie-ups are aimed at bringing convenience to millions of Indians travelling to Europe every year. Worldline stands out as the largest merchant aggregator in Europe. We have entered into a definitive agreement with global digital payments infrastructure provider PPRO for merchant payments (both at point-of-sale and e-commerce level). This partnership will enable UPI acceptance across multiple countries, including the UK, soon. We have also established a partnership with Lyra, a leading French entity specialising in e-commerce. We recently announced the acceptance of UPI payments in France. The Eiffel Tower has become the first merchant to accept payment from UPI-powered apps in Europe. **BT**

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